

Amp Recipes

Twelve starting settings for the sounds you already love

Guitar, pedal and amp settings for twelve classic sounds, drawn as knob positions on a 0 to 10 scale. Treat each as a starting point for your own amp, room and hands.

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Free from guitarhub.org. Share it, print it, pin it above the amp. The interactive versions of these ideas live at guitarhub.org/tone.

METHOD

How to use a recipe

Every amp is voiced differently, so noon on one amp is not noon on another. A recipe tells you the shape of a sound. Your ears finish it.

- 1 Set the knobs as drawn, at the volume you will actually play.
- 2 Play the kind of part the sound is for, not a random riff.
- 3 Adjust gain first, then mids, then bass and treble. One knob at a time.
- 4 Write down where you ended up for your amp. That is your recipe now.

Knobs are drawn on a 0 to 10 scale. If your amp's EQ runs 1 to 10 or has no numbers, match the pointer position instead.

Which knob matters most

Sound family	The knob to get right first
Cleans	Gain. Low enough that the hardest strum stays clean.
Edge of breakup	Your guitar volume. It is the gain control while playing.
Crunch and rock	Mids. They decide whether you are heard.
High gain	Bass. Too much and palm mutes turn to mush.
Ambient	Delay mix. Keep repeats just under the note.

Clean sounds

Glassy clean

Guitar: Neck or middle single-coil



Pedals: Light compressor, subtle chorus, room reverb

Keep gain low enough that hard strums stay clean.

Warm jazz

Guitar: Neck humbucker, tone at 5



Pedals: None, or a touch of room reverb

Pick with the thumb or a heavy pick for a round attack.

Funk rhythm

Guitar: Middle or neck and middle



Pedals: Compressor with fast attack, optional envelope filter

Mute hard with the fretting hand; the compressor evens the scratches.

Country snap

Guitar: Bridge single-coil



Pedals: Compressor, short slapback delay near 120 ms

Hybrid picking and the bridge pickup do most of the work.

Driven sounds

Edge of breakup

Guitar: Any, volume at 10



Pedals: Low-gain overdrive, level up, drive low

Guitar volume at 7 for rhythm, 10 for the solo.

Texas blues lead

Guitar: Neck single-coil



Pedals: Mid-hump overdrive, spring reverb

Heavier strings and a hard attack fatten it.

Classic rock crunch

Guitar: Bridge humbucker



Pedals: Optional overdrive to push the amp

Mids are what make the chords sit in a band.

Hard rock lead

Guitar: Bridge humbucker



Pedals: Overdrive in front, delay around 400 ms low in the mix

Add delay, not gain, when a lead needs to be bigger.

High gain, fuzz and ambient

Tight high gain

Guitar: Bridge humbucker



Pedals: Overdrive with drive near zero and level up, noise gate

The boost trims low end before the amp so mutes stay tight.

Wall of fuzz

Guitar: Bridge or neck, fuzz first



Pedals: Fuzz straight from the guitar, short reverb

Roll guitar volume back and many fuzzes clean up.

Indie jangle

Guitar: Bridge and middle, or a 12-string



Pedals: Compressor, bright chorus

Open chord voicings with ringing strings sell it.

Ambient swells

Guitar: Neck pickup, volume at 0



Pedals: Compressor, mild drive, delay 450 to 600 ms with many repeats, long reverb

Fade each note in with the volume knob or a volume pedal.

Hear six of these in the free Pedal Lab: guitarhub.org/pedal-lab.